SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #49 · GENDER ROLES AND EXPECTATIONS

"I must be the strong one, no matter what."

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Where it often comes from

The oldest child, the caregiver, the spouse who "keeps it together," or the one who learned early that no one else would. Others depend on us, and we feel we have no right to fall apart. Over time, exhaustion, resentment, and isolation build.

What Scripture teaches

Paul says, "My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness." "Cast your burden upon the LORD and He will sustain you." "Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest." "Carry one another's burdens." Moses needed Aaron and Hur to hold up his arms. We are not meant to be the source of strength for everyone. God is. Our job is to lean on Him and let others share the load.

> *"Cast your burden upon the LORD and He will sustain you; He will never let the righteous be shaken"* (Psalm 55:22).

Also see

> "But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me. That is why, for the sake of Christ, I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in hardships, in persecutions, in difficulties. For when I am weak, then I am strong" (2 Corinthians 12:9–10).

> "Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest. Take My yoke upon you and learn from Me; for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls. For My yoke is easy and My burden is light" (Matthew 11:28–30).

> "Carry one another's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ" (Galatians 6:2).

> "Two are better than one, because they have a good return for their labor. For if one falls down, his companion can lift him up; but pity the one who falls without another to help him up!" (Ecclesiastes 4:9–10).

Common self-statements

- If I fall apart, everything falls apart.
- No one else can handle this.
- I do not get to be weak.
- Others depend on me.
- I have to hold it together.
- I cannot let anyone down.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either strong or a failure.
- Mind reading: Assuming others cannot cope without me.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling needed and concluding that I cannot stop.
- Fortune telling: Predicting disaster if I rest.

Challenging questions

- When did I first become “the strong one”?
- What would really happen if I rested or asked for help?
- Who could share some of the load?
- What does God say about being sustained?
- What have I lost by never leaning?
- What is one thing I can hand off?

Truth summary

> God is the strong one. I can cast my burdens on Him, let others share the load, and rest. My weakness is not the end of the world. It is where His power is seen.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Tired
- Weakness
- Trust
- Friendship
- Anxiety/Worry

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Divorce

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God’s care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

Living Hope — Phil Wickham
Christ’s resurrection and forgiveness provide hope beyond sin and death.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I must be the strong one, no matter what"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I must be the strong one, no matter what." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ When did this begin?
- ☐ What would really happen?
- ☐ Who could help?
- ☐ What does God say?
- ☐ What have I lost?
- ☐ What can I hand off?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God sustains me.
- ☐ His power is perfected in weakness.
- ☐ Jesus gives rest to the weary.
- ☐ We carry burdens together.
- ☐ Others can share the load.
- ☐ I can rest.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 55:22
  "Cast your burden upon the LORD and He will sustain you; He will never let the righteous be shaken."
- ☐ 2 Corinthians 12:9–10
  "But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me. That is why, for the sake of Christ, I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in hardships, in persecutions, in difficulties. For when I am weak, then I am strong."
- ☐ Galatians 6:2
  "Carry one another's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Lean and rest: Each week, note one load you shared or handed off.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 55:22 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I will cast my burden on the Lord and He will sustain me.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Tired" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ List your loads. Write everything you carry.
- ☐ Hand off one. Ask someone to take one task.
- ☐ Rest on purpose. Schedule real rest.
- ☐ Pray Psalm 55:22. Cast your burden daily.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I must be the strong one, no matter what": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Lean and rest
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must be the strong one, no matter what.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have been the strong one for too long. I cast my burdens on You. Sustain me, and send people to share the load. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.